

PRELUDE XXII

EVER since Spitta commented (with a vague indication of distress) on the complexity of the opening of this Prelude, it has had a reputation for obscurity. The trouble arises merely from confusing figures with whole themes and themes with whole phrases; on which procedure Handel becomes the obscurest composer that ever lived. It may safely be said that nobody will find any difficulty in following this Prelude if from the outset the player shows his sense of form by giving the first seven bars as a single statement without any sign of anxiety lest the upper part should “obscure the theme” in the middle. The upper part is a perfectly natural way of continuing the sentence; the middle voice comes out quite clearly through it, and no listener will be worried by the fact that in the following counter-statement the counterpoints are new. The counter-statement, in the dominant, expands into a regular eight-bar period, beginning at bar 8 and closing into bar 16. This bar attaches itself to that period, and a new eight-bar period starts at bar 17, and leads back to the tonic. At bar 25 the bass resumes the main theme and in six bars carries it to D $\flat$ major, where, at bar 31, the treble gives it out again, and in another six bars reaches A $\flat$ (more as dominant of D $\flat$ than as an independent key). The five bars from bars 37-41 contain an important new incident, and close into a version of the main theme starting in the bass in A $\flat$ (with a neat turn of the position) in bar 42, and continued by the middle voice in E $\flat$ minor, reaching in six bars the key of G $\flat$. Here, again (bar 48), the theme sets out in the middle voice, continued by the treble, and carried in six bars plus one (as at the outset) again to the sub-dominant E $\flat$ minor. And now from bars 55-70 we have a faithful recapitulation of bars 1-16 a fourth higher and fifth lower, with the upper voices interchanged. With bar 70 the Coda begins, rising to a climax on a dominant pedal, and ending with a reproduction a tone higher of the incident of bars 37-41. Having thus fixed the periods (which turn out to be mostly six-bar phrases with an occasional link-bar added; the six being, of course, 4 $\times$ 2) we can now afford to notice the wonderful thematic figure-work. The first theme obviously contains two distinct melodies, apart from its prolific initial four quavers. Its second melody is, of course, that of the middle voice from bar 3 $\frac{1}{2}$ -5. The inversion of bar 1 in the bass of bars 5-6, is easily seen. The link-bar 7 contains a figure which, direct and inverted, constitutes most of the rest of the counterpoint (especially in the bass), makes all the other link-bars, and builds up the climax in the Coda. Quiet singing, *legato* playing (some crotchets admitting of gentle detachment) doing justice to all three voices, will bring all these points out without breaking the periods, which are all-important and quite independent of them. The *tempo* is a flowing four or very gentle two, with only one accent in the bar.

FUGUE XXII

THE *staccato* dashes which Bach has given to the Subject (in his pupils' MSS.) are, like all his few marks and the many marks of later great masters, highly practical as making for transparency in the part-writing. The crotchets of the second bar should be only just detached, the tone there becoming more yielding, and the rest of the Subject gravely *cantabile*. The *staccato* must

* Melodically, of course, each part begins the period with its own anacrusis in bar 16: viz., three quavers in the treble, a crotchet in the middle, and seven quavers in the bass.

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not be forgotten in the subsequent entries, both of the Direct and the Inverted Subject. The equally important Countersubject will contrast best if it is given in a swelling *legato*, which will account for the volume of tone necessary for the long note suspended from bar 7 into bar 8. As there are 101 bars to fill with the climaxes of this mighty scheme, the tone must be rigorously economised from the outset, and every resource used to keep variety and life in values below *mezzo-forte* for the first half of the Fugue. The entries and Stretti of the Subject are arranged in a very orderly scheme, which it will be convenient to summarise first. The exposition of Subject and Countersubject occupies bars 1-20; the order being alto, soprano, bass, tenor, and the Countersubject being, of course, in the voice that last had the Subject. The First Stretto, in the upper seventh at a minim's distance, is between tenor and alto, starting in bar 27; the remaining parts have it shortly afterwards in D $\flat$, turned round as a Stretto between soprano and bass in the lower ninth (bar 33). At bar 42 begins an exposition of the Inverted Subject with the Inverted Countersubject in all four parts: tenor (Countersubject in alto), bar 42; alto (with tenor), bar 46; soprano (with alto), bar 52; and bass (with soprano, the first bar of the Countersubject obliterated), bar 58. The Inverted Stretto soon follows: bar 67, tenor and soprano in upper ninth; and bar 73, alto and bass in lower seventh. Within three bars of the end of this the Third Stretto appears; the Inverted Subject in the soprano being answered by the Direct Subject (beginning on the leading-note) in the tenor (bar 80). After an Episode, the converse of this Stretto appears in bar 89, the bass leading with the Direct Subject and the alto answering with the Inversion. Again within three bars of the end of this, the Final Stretto bursts out in all four parts at once (bar 96) by adding thirds and sixths to the Stretto just given, and putting the Direct Subject into the upper parts. These Stretti represent about one-sixteenth of what Bach would have brought forward if he had worked this Fugue out on the exhaustive lines of the evidently early D $\sharp$ minor and A minor Fugues of Book I., for here not only does he always put the leader of the Stretto into the cardinal position of the scale and the bar, never exploiting the forms in which it is the leader that is displaced, but he takes only the closest Stretti, whereas the Subject admits of two other equally complete sets of Stretti, one at the octave after two minims, and the other at the ninth at a whole bar. All these combinations are equally harmonious; running, like those chosen, in thirds or sixths.

Wonderful as is the present scheme of Stretti, it owes its rhetorical power first to the intrinsic beauty of the Subject; which, far from losing poetry when it is inverted, gives rise in that shape to some of the grandest sequences in the whole piece; and, secondly, to the Episodes. The first of these, as constantly in Bach, arises from the end of the Subject and Countersubject before the third voice has entered (bars 8-10). Episodes 2 and 3 (bars 15-16, 21-26) develop on its lines. Episode 4 prepares the way for the Inverted Countersubject by combining in Triple Counterpoint a new offshoot of the last figure of the Subject with a descending chromatic figure and certain episodic phrases, and is instantly given in three of its permutations (bars 37-41). Episode 5 (bars 62-66) develops the end of the Inverted Subject into a new and urgent quaver figure which takes shape in the bass as a grandly indignant and insistent tonic pedal to underly the Inverted Stretto down to bar 69. The three bars from 76-79 show what force lies in the end of the Inverted Subject; and the last Episode, arising out of bar 83, builds it into wonderful imitative sequences in four-crotchet steps across the triple time.